on a large-scale, resulting in distribution of colonial territories and the delineation of spheres of influence in China and elsewhere, among the European powers. Partition or division of territories has also been used in the maintenance of balance of power. A Plethora of examples are available in this regard, like the division of the Spanish possessions in Europe and outside among the Hapsburg and the Bourbons under the Treaty of Utrecht, the partition of Poland and later its division among Russia, Prussia and Austria, partition of Germany by the Treaty of Versailles and again after the Second World War among Britain, France, Russia and the United States, and division of Korea and Vietnam after the Second World War.

3. ***Buffer States:*** Geo-strategically, some states may be placed in between some powerful states in such a way that they tend to keep rival powers out of direct contact with each other. They come to constitute a buffer between the two. Palmer and Perkins point out that buffer states are of great importance because of their cushioning effect between the great powers. They may be neutral or neutralized states, satellite states or dependent territories, or even may be actively associated with one of two or more aggregations of power in a relatively honourable way.

One of the important buffer regions of the world has been the one separating the Soviet Union from the non-Communist powers, an area comprising weak states, vast distances, geographical barriers, conflicting interests of superpowers during the post-War period and rising nationalisms. This may roughly correspond to the idea of a large part of the *Inner Crescent* of Mackinder and the *Rimland* of Spykman. Afghanistan long served as a buffer state between Russia and pre-independent India. Similarly, Tibet was also a buffer between China and India during the British India and even during the initial years of independence of India. But in both the cases, the Soviet intervention in Afghanistan in 1979 disturbed its buffer status, and recent Chinese occupation of Tibet has destroyed its buffer character. Nepal and Bhutan also serve as a buffer between China and India. Thus both India and China follow a cautious foreign policy towards Nepal and Bhutan. Several lines, such as the 17th Parallel in Vietnam and the 38th Parallel in Korea, also serve similar purposes, as that of the buffer states.